

Runbook: Incident Response Process and Severity Definitions

Meridian Commercial Bank - Internal Document

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Purpose

Defines the standard incident response process at Meridian Commercial Bank, including severity levels, roles, and communication expectations. This process applies to all production incidents regardless of department.

Severity Definitions

- Critical: Full outage of a customer-facing or payment-critical service, or any incident involving incorrect movement of customer funds. Page immediately, all-hands response, executive notification within 30 minutes.
- High: Significant degradation (partial outage, elevated error rate above 5%) of a customer-facing or payment-critical service. Page on-call immediately.
- Medium: Degradation of a non-critical service or a critical service with a known workaround. Notify on-call, response during business hours if outside working hours.
- Low: Minor issue with no material customer impact. Track as a ticket, no paging required.

Roles

- Incident Commander (IC): Owns the incident timeline, coordinates responders, makes the call on major decisions (e.g., failover, rollback). For Critical incidents, the IC is a designated Staff+ engineer or engineering manager.
- Technical Lead: The subject-matter expert actively diagnosing and fixing the issue (often the paged on-call engineer).
- Communications Lead: Owns customer/stakeholder communication, status page updates, and internal updates in #incident-<name>.

Process

1. Detect: Alert fires or issue is reported.
2. Triage: On-call assesses severity using the definitions above.
3. Declare: For High/Critical, formally declare an incident (creates an incident channel, assigns IC).
4. Mitigate: Focus on restoring service first; root cause analysis can wait.
5. Resolve: Confirm service restored via monitoring/synthetic checks.
6. Document: Write the incident report within 2 business days using the standard incident report template (see any file under docs/incident_reports for the expected format: Summary, Timeline, Root Cause, Impact, Resolution, Action Items).
7. Review: Blameless postmortem review within 1 week for High/Critical

incidents; action items tracked to completion.

Communication Cadence

- Critical: updates every 15 minutes until mitigated.
- High: updates every 30 minutes until mitigated.
- Medium/Low: update on state changes only.

Related Documents

- RB-payment-gateway-failover, RB-database-restore (service-specific runbooks referenced during triage/mitigate steps)